A tilt and a coup

India had introduced various developmental projects in Afghanistan by the 1970s. These included the Chardeghorband Microhydel Scheme, the Indira Gandhi Hospital in Kabul, series of technical assistance schemes in the field of planning, industry, mining, irrigation, and power. Agricultural research stations were also established in Bamiyan, Kandahar, and Kabul for rice, wheat and potatoes.[46] Though reflecting political warmth, these projects had their basis laid in a geopolitical rationale that was shaped more by pressures of the global Cold War, than by the principle of non-alignment. The situation developed along four axes. Firstly, creation of Bangladesh in 1971, and then India's nuclear test in May 1974, emboldened Baloch and Pashtun separatists in Pakistan. The National Awami Party (NAP), which was then the principal political adversary of the Zulfiqar Ali Bhutto-led Pakistan People's Party (PPP), had swept across Balochistan and the NWFP in the 1970 general elections. Led by Ghaffar Khan's son, Khan Wali Khan, the NAP had strong sociopolitical links with Afghanistan and symbolised the nationalistic aspirations of both the Baloch and Pashtun people, similar to the Awami League in East Pakistan.[47] Though the NAP formed the provincial government in May 1972 (Ataullah Mengal, a leading feudal chief, became Balochistan's chief minister), it remained marred by a series of internal crises as well as political turbulence with Islamabad.[48]

Such secessionist tendencies in Pakistan and Islamabad's violent response, unnerved Kabul, which worried about the perverse impact on its polity, society, and economy (if West Pakistan's stability was disturbed).[49] Kabul's concern about Pakistan's disintegration was not new. The situation in East Pakistan in 1971 had made Zahir Shah equally 'anxious' about the perverse impact of Pakistan's heavy-handedness in dealing with ethnic and linguistic minorities in Afghanistan. He admitted to the US ambassador that while his government had been tight-lipped about the East Pakistan affair, public opinion across Afghanistan heavily favoured the Bengalis.[50] Disconnect between Kabul's concerns about the situation in East Pakistan and popular support for armed Indian intervention among Afghans was not lost upon the Indian leadership. Gandhi's confidante and Indian ambassador to Moscow, D P Dhar, had asked foreign secretary Triloki Nath Kaul to suggest